



This Irish Republican barricade was set up across Townsend Street in Dublin during the Easter Rising to delay the advance of British troops fighting to retake the city.

A YEAR OF BATTLES OF UNPRECEDENTED SCALE

opened with a German offensive against the French city of **Verdun** in February (see pp.344–45). German commander-in-chief Erich von Falkenhayn (1861–1922) aimed to “bleed the French army white” by drawing it into costly combat. The French reacted as he had hoped by sending reinforcements, decimated by the German heavy guns. German losses also mounted up, as French resistance stiffened under the inspirational leadership of General Philippe Pétain (1856–1975). Repeated **German offensives** continued until mid-July, after which **French counteroffensives** succeeded into December. Little territory changed hands and both sides suffered around 400,000 casualties.

Meanwhile, the US was fighting a war on a quite different scale.



In March, Mexican general **Pancho Villa** (1878–1923), the flamboyant leader of one of the revolutionary armies engaged in Mexico’s ongoing civil war, made a **cross-border raid into the US**. His attack on Columbus, New Mexico, was rebuffed by the US Cavalry. The provocation was too great for the US to ignore, and President Woodrow Wilson (1856–1924) ordered General John Pershing (1860–1948) to lead an expedition into Mexico. Around 5,000 US troops fought engagements with both Villa supporters and Mexican government forces before withdrawing in January 1917.

Britain suffered a **military disaster** in the spring in Mesopotamia (Iraq), then part of the Turkish Ottoman Empire. The area had been occupied by British forces from India. From December 1915, Anglo-Indian troops had been **under siege by Turkish forces at Kut-al-Amara**, between Basra and Baghdad. Relief forces failed to fight their way through to Kut, so, facing starvation, they were forced to surrender. Taken prisoner, the British and Indian soldiers endured terrible hardship, less than half surviving captivity.

Bandit leader

Originally a bandit chief, **Pancho Villa** became a key figure in the Mexican Revolution and Mexico’s clash with the US in 1916.

Prussian
wappen, or
helmet
plate



German helmet

The German spiked *Pickelhaube* helmet was replaced in the course of 1916 by the metal *Stahlhelm*, which provided better protection.

This disaster was offset by the **Arab revolt against Turkish rule**. Encouraged by Britain, Hussein bin Ali, Sharif of Mecca (1854–1931), launched an uprising in June. Arab forces defeated the Turkish garrisons of Mecca, Medina, and other towns in the Hejaz, and Hussein proclaimed himself Sultan of the Arabs. The British sent **T.E. Lawrence** (1888–1935), a junior officer in Cairo, to act as adviser to Hussein’s son Feisal, the most active leader of the revolt. Between them, Lawrence and Feisal organized an effective military force. They used guerrilla tactics to push for the liberation of Arabs throughout the Turkish-ruled Middle East.

In April, **Britain** faced a revolt against its rule in Ireland. The Irish Republican Brotherhood sought German support for a nationalist uprising, but Germany’s attempt to supply rifles to the rebels was intercepted by the British.

Republicans still went ahead with the **uprising on Easter Monday**, occupying key buildings in Dublin, and proclaiming a Provisional Government of the Irish Republic. The British sent troops to Dublin, and after five days of fighting the rebels surrendered. Fifteen republican leaders were executed after a secret trial by a British military court. Although few Irish had supported the rebellion, the executions stimulated a wave of pro-Republican sentiment.

At the end of May, the German High Seas Fleet and the Royal Navy’s Grand Fleet met in the **Battle of Jutland** in the North Sea. The British spotted a sortie by the German fleet and sent a far superior naval force to attack it. German Admiral Reinhard Scheer (1863–1928) was caught by surprise, but British Admiral John Jellicoe (1859–1935) failed to profit from the advantage. The German warships were able to make a fighting withdrawal to port, while inflicting heavier losses than they suffered. Despite a disappointing performance, the Royal Navy had confirmed its superiority—it was the German fleet that had retreated.

In June, General Aleksei Brusilov (1853–1926) mounted

Russia’s most successful offensive of World War I, almost destroying the Austrian army in Galicia. The Austrians were only rescued by the arrival of German troops to support them. Brusilov’s initial success was based on subtle tactics—surprise and the rapid movement of shock troops to exploit breakthroughs.

Unfortunately, the British did not learn from their Russian allies. On July 1, General Douglas Haig



GENERAL DOUGLAS HAIG (1861–1928)

Cavalry officer Douglas Haig performed well as a corps commander in the first year of World War I. As British army commander-in-chief, his assaults on German defenses at the Somme in 1916 and Passchendaele in 1917 resulted in huge losses. In 1918, Haig held firm in the face of the formidable German spring offensives, then presided over a string of British victories.

